

**Mutual Aid and Refugee Support Ethnographic Study and Platform
Intervention**

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Introduction

In response to recent U.S. policies targeting displaced populations and efforts to suppress college protests, many organizers have shifted their focus to online activism. While this shift has helped some groups reach wider audiences, others face challenges due to censorship. Since many social media platforms are privately owned, they are not required to uphold the same free speech protections guaranteed to U.S. citizens. As a result, some activists have been censored while trying to share their messages.

This experience sparked our interest in how grassroots movements and community organizations navigate the evolving social media landscape. Through interviews with groups focused on mutual aid and refugee support, we aim to design an online platform that connects refugee communities with campus initiatives, helping to reduce the effects of online suppression. The platform will help local communities engage with refugee organizations through a website, which will ideally facilitate effective communication and help build stronger connections among students, activists, and community members. Additionally, social media and the internet have become prolific areas for people to outsource for help and resources, and call attention to issues impacting the community. This form of active news-focused communication is something that we could also consider integrating into our website by adding a policy updates tab and call to action areas where news and resources can be spread.

Before creating our website design, we first utilized an ethnographic study approach to understand the needs of three organizations dedicated to refugee needs and mutual aid, which will shape the development of our platform. From the interviews, some common pain points our partner organizations faced are issues with sharing timely federal and local policy updates, maintaining a comprehensive digital archive of their work, and archiving important resources

that community members could use in the future. Along with this, we read and compared articles and research papers that discussed both social media and organized movements.

Background

In preparation for developing our question(s) of research, we looked for papers that specifically addressed the relationship between online social platforms and political activism, along with successful constructs of mutual aid. For inspiration, we initially thought of social media profiles created for refugee families and bail funds. We've collectively witnessed successful donation self-promotions that often meet and at times exceed donation goals through the use of only social media platforms. This connection between technological and in-person social interaction is not often seen in this day and age, with fan communities, long-distance internet friends, or anonymous "moots" (mutual followers) often staying strictly online. It is thus refreshing and uplifting to see community movement and a willingness to integrate practices of change into their daily lives when it comes to issues that impact the livelihood and safety of others.

One of the readings we engaged with, *Quantifying the Power and Consequences of Social Media Protest*, displayed a very important aspect of how justice and injustices are brought to light to many via social media. Often garnering three very important aspects to any social movement: unity, numbers, and commitment. In 2016, Black Lives Matter discussions and information were widely spread on Twitter. The discontent grew more and more until in-person protests came about as a result of this, initially, Twitter social movement. This aspect greatly influenced our decision to add a section to our website as not only a means of resources, but as a means of educating and uniting others for this cause, and helping to bring more awareness to the

communities we want to prioritize, mutual aid and support for refugees. This not only creates a space for these resources to be found, but also to spread what can be done to help as well.

Another reading that we found to have some useful information for our cause was chapter 10 of *Routledge Handbook of Contemporary Hong Kong, Social Media and Social Mobilization*. This chapter goes in depth on how political opinions are frequently shared on social media sites as the concern for censored news became more and more prevalent in Hong Kong. Regardless, public radio and social media created opportunities and more access to information and news, spreading. Hong Kong has these innovations to thank for its nickname- “The City of Protest”. Regardless of the censorship under the government, the people refused to be silenced and continued to speak out about injustices and discrimination, allowing more protests to be organized. We were inspired by the citizens of Hong Kong who chose to attend protests, it is especially relevant under the current United States political climate bringing about fear of censorship once again. We hope that we can help to innovate in some type of way to continue the progression of accessible online activism for local communities.

From the research and analysis of Brennan in *HOW DIGITAL MEDIA RESHAPES POLITICAL ACTIVISM: MASS PROTESTS, SOCIAL MOBILIZATION, AND CIVIC ENGAGEMENT*, they found, “Social media sites help bring new voices into political discussion and help people get involved with issues that matter to them.” (p.77-78). In section 4 “Results and Discussion” of data from the Pew Research Center (survey among 2,008 individuals in December of 2017) asks social media users how they feel political discussions are in terms of decency shown. The majority revealed that discussions of politics are described as less respectful, civil, informative, and less likely to come to a resolution among others. This analysis was seen in conjunction with an increase in political action taken via social media such as taking

part in a group that has interest in a specific cause, encouraging action for issues you care about, looking up information on local protests/ rallies, etc (from the same set of individuals surveyed about political decency). This shows that, though we may be less likely to come to a compromise or agreement, we are more politically involved with the causes they care about and are becoming more educated on the topic by using social media. Through this, Brennan concluded, “Media and interaction may mediate a portion of the effect of the social psychological aspects on protest engagement”(pg. 80). This analysis only further encouraged our group to center on creating a site to readily access information on ways to get involved with mutual aid in your community, using a technological platform to mobilize action offline such as rallies, protests, food banks, clothing drives, etc.

One last reading that our group found to be influential was Harlow & Harp’s *COLLECTIVE ACTION ON THE WEB: A Cross-Cultural Study of Social Networking Sites and Online and Offline Activism in the United States and Latin America*, a study of United States and Latin American activists and their perception of social networking sites (SNS) for activism. Though the study was conducted in 2011, and technology has vastly increased since then, the findings of this study only prove to be more relevant. The study found, through a little over 200 participants of an online survey, that SNSs, particularly Facebook and Twitter, were valuable sources to mobilize supporters for a cause online and offline. Both United States and Latin American activists claimed that they participate in both online and offline activism, and often viewed online activism to be a precursor to offline activism. These findings helped to ensure our understanding of how online activism sources can be helpful, but the activism that is most regarded and often legitimizing is done in person. One respondent was quoted stating, “...there is nothing like actually showing up in person and doing the hard work” (pg 208). This was thus our

intention with our prototype, to be discussed later in this paper. Our goal is to create an online platform to encourage outreach and involvement in community-based mutual aid in the hopes of inspiring more offline actions from what was at first an online community.

Methodology

For our research, we took an ethnographic approach to examine how immigrant, refugee, and mutual aid organizations are navigating the political climate on campus. Additionally, we wanted to learn about how they are trying to organize within the institution's restraints. Utilizing an ethnographic approach in our study made sense for our particular research questions because we were interested in seeing if there were common struggles between organizations that shared similar mission statements. Since some of our researchers had developed a rapport with three organizations that operated within the refugee and mutual aid space, we contacted them to conduct informal interviews about their pain points as local organizations. It would also give us insight into administrative obstacles they are facing, whether they be from campus or federal policies. The organizations that we conducted interviews with will be referred to as O1, O2, and O3. O1 and O2 both focus on aiding refugee communities on a global and local scale, respectively. Meanwhile, O3 places its efforts in gathering resources and offering mutual aid to local community members.

When conducting the interviews, we sought the following questions:

- How are refugee organizations relaying event information to their communities? Can this method be improved?
- How can digital tools enhance connections between college-based initiatives and local refugee organizations?

- What are the biggest challenges refugee organizations face when engaging with local communities online?
- Are there limitations to how you can platform your organization on digital campus spaces?
- What security and privacy measures are necessary to protect activists using the platform?
- How do different organizations currently use technology for organizing, and what improvements do they need?
- What specific features would make an online platform useful for activists and organizations that may not be allowed to engage in physical, centralized organizing?

O1 and O3: Challenges of Students Organizing

Due to anonymity purposes, this will be a general description of what we gathered from interviews with O1 and O3, after they shared wanting to protect their identities by not using direct quotes from our conversations. During the first interview with O1, we learned that many campus organizations struggle to streamline communication with both their members and the communities they partner with, whether it's coordinating events or sharing important information. O3 echoed similar challenges and also described difficulties in protecting their members' identities when engaging with different communities. As student-led organizations, both O1 and O3 expressed frustrations with the institution's administration, including the need to navigate the institution's organization handbook and instances of pushback from administrators regarding how they conduct their work. In light of increasing attacks on universities and colleges nationwide by the current presidential administration as of April 2025, both groups have been adapting how they organize and support their communities. Emphasizing the importance to both

organizations for centralization and the archive of resources to ensure they are easily accessible to community members.

O2: Challenges of Organizing Within an Institution

Our final community partner is an organization that operates within the confines of a larger institution that has recently begun removing mentions of DEI. This change was influenced by recent updates in policies set by the current presidential administration as of April 2025. Due to this policy setback, the institution is making changes to DEI mentions on their official websites and additional digital spaces. However, it should be noted that in removing or reworking DEI messages, some administration members have conveyed that they are trying to protect community members, though this approach has caused differing reactions. Some internal organizations have viewed this move as an infringement on free expression, while others have become hesitant about publishing their efforts around DEI.

One such organization facing this hesitation is O2, which has received direct communication from their director that they should be careful around mentioning overt DEI engagement. This falls in stark contrast to the mission of their organization, which focuses on specifically aiding refugee community members through partnerships with local non-profits. In communication with an activist fellow who works with O2, she mentioned the lack of publicity about O2 on the website page dedicated to the umbrella organization that O2 falls under. This site is located within the institution's digital space. She went on to state, “There is mention about all of the other initiatives, but nothing regarding O2, which I thought was interesting”. Due to a lack of publicity on the institution's website, it has proven difficult to recruit new members, though there have been efforts made by posterage around the institution's property and sharing

information via newsletters. However, this potential censoring of the organization has not stopped O2 from creating plans to carve out a space for itself on the institution's website. “We are thinking of having a tab that has a blurb that explains what O2 stands for, such as offering support for immigrants and refugee families. If someone is interested in helping, then they can see additional contact information to reach out to [redacted]. There would also be an archive with pictures of past events and a link to a resources document.” After our conversation, a question arose about what O2’s current digital resource archive looked like since their activist friend mentioned creating a resource document for their planned tab section.

We reached out to an admin of O2 to discuss their current efforts to archive and centralize resources that can later be used to support community partners. The O2 admin mentioned, “A couple of summers ago, a fellow dedicated their internship time to gathering resources that we can share with families that we work with and information that we can use as advocates to keep track of who we are supporting. The information is housed both within our Google Drive folders and on a larger resource document. However, if you want to find something, you really need to know what you are looking for and have a lot of patience.” Another downside of having an archive that is not user-friendly is that resources become outdated. “We have a funding and grants section in the file, but the last time it was updated was in 2023.” Although there are some pitfalls with navigating O2’s current archive, the admin considered compiling the resource document a wonderful first step compared to word-of-mouth resource gathering that they had previously utilized. She shared hopes of what she thinks would be beneficial to families as O2 continues to expand their work, “For us as advocates, sometimes I think about how we want to make sure that we aren’t creating something new when there is an organization that is already doing the work. Having an archive of some sort where we can know what other local

resettlement organizations are doing and connect them to our families would be wonderful”. At the end of our interview, we still had questions about what current volunteers were doing to support O2. She directed me to talk to a volunteer who has been an integral part of restructuring the organization so that current and future volunteers have a better understanding of all the ways they can contribute to O2’s mission.

Finally, we reached out to the volunteer who is helping in the restructuring of O2 and who had thoughts on what they would like to improve with resource sharing. Before this restructuring, they were all split between family groups that they would check in on, and additional miscellaneous tasks. With a new team structure, they are hoping to create different committee groups that volunteers can become a part of, that could fit different individual capacities. She hopes that this change in structure will also encourage more volunteers to sign up to help with O2’s needs, but promotion of this restructuring has been limited due to changes in DEI policies. As we continued our conversation to gather more interest in O2’s work, we began to touch on social media platforms. Both their potential use for promotion and the drawbacks given the current political climate in the United States, “I think an Instagram or webpage would be an awesome way to get more volunteers interested in our work, but we need to be careful. Have you talked to [redacted]? She might help a lot with what we are and are not allowed to post, but essentially, because of the current administration, we can’t really publicize things related to O2 and tie it back to the institution. It might place them as a target.” This worry of potential safety threats made the volunteer wary of creating a platform that existed within or around the institution, but it did not deter her motivation to create a space where families working with O2 and even lawyers can quickly get information on what resources are available. “Given how quickly everything is changing with policies, not only are many non-profits behind,

but even lawyers...immigration lawyers are behind. Having some way to share policy changes would be very beneficial, but I also think just going out there and creating a document that has accurate resources is a good first step.” After further discussion, the volunteer thought that integrating recent news in our website ideation process would greatly serve the community, so everyone can stay up to date as policies around immigration and refugee status continue to change. Once we had concluded our conversations with O2, we began to draw commonalities between our partner organizations.

Commonalities

After conducting informal interviews with O1, O2, and O3, a few common pain points arose that have prevented them from operating at their fullest capacity. First, there was a desire to have a platform that could house an archive of organizational content, such as photos and videos taken at events. In particular, some expressed that students who are interested in the organizations might not take the initiative to join since there is no immediate context of what impact the organizations have had on local communities. Having an archive that showcases real community interaction that the organizations have supported would help in promoting the organization's mission to a wider student activist audience.

In line with archival work, many expressed wanting to centralize resources so that future community partners could easily access information on grants, lawyers they can connect with, food networks, etc. Currently, our focus organizations have a decentralized way of handling resources, whether that be through students hosting the information in a personal and private document, word of mouth, or a Google Drive that is difficult to navigate. Creating a space on a

website that places the resources out in the open for quick reference would greatly help their community partners and student activists with engaging in mutual aid through the organizations.

There is also an issue with communication across all organizations, where some student volunteers have felt that they are overwhelmed with the volume of communication that takes place between them and community partners. Some organizations, like O1, have begun to implement Google phone numbers to help resolve the problem of one volunteer taking on a vast amount of communication and aid. However, a more streamlined communication space would help a team of volunteers to stay on top of urgent requests and communication without it falling on one or two students.

Lastly, all organizations expressed high difficulty in recruiting new members, with some organizations utilizing word-of-mouth calls to action and others trying to advertise on institutional platforms. None have been very successful, so centralizing recruitment information would help grow the organizations and keep them alive for years to come.

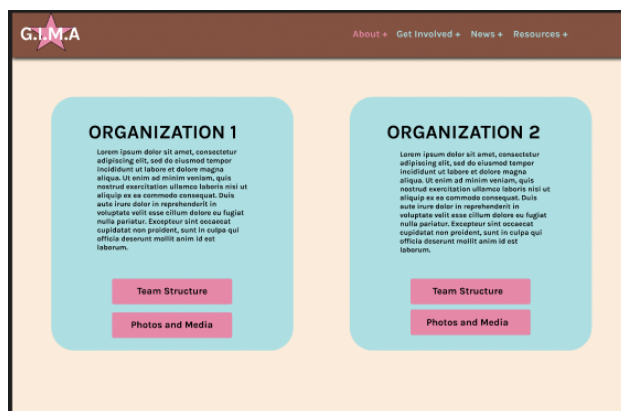
Design of Website Ideation Prototype

Before designing the prototype, we made sure to take inspiration from other webpages that have similar missions. We specifically took inspiration from websites located on the institution's website that housed another branch organization's archival information. Although we are creating a website that will help address some of the issues that our community partners are experiencing, our prototype is focused on creating a comprehensive archive and resources hub. Our FIGMA ideation prototype is designed to centralize information, making it easier for community members to access resources, connect with different organizations, and stay informed through a shared calendar of events.

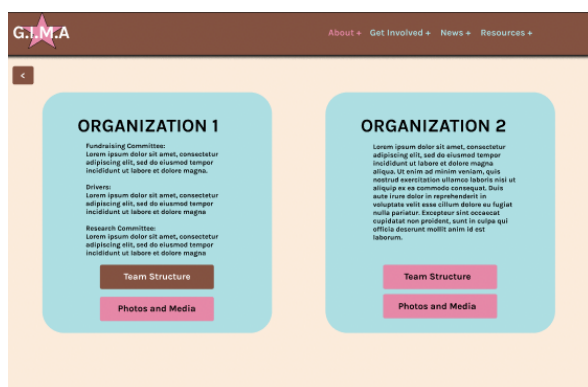
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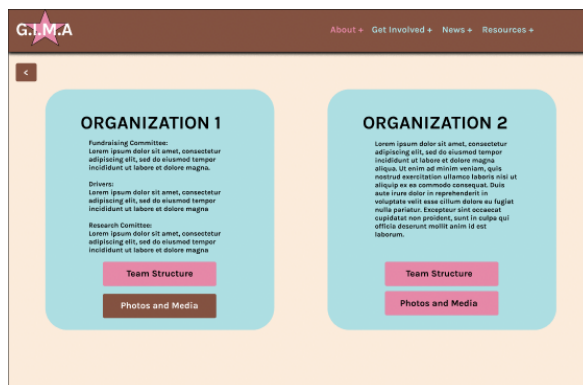
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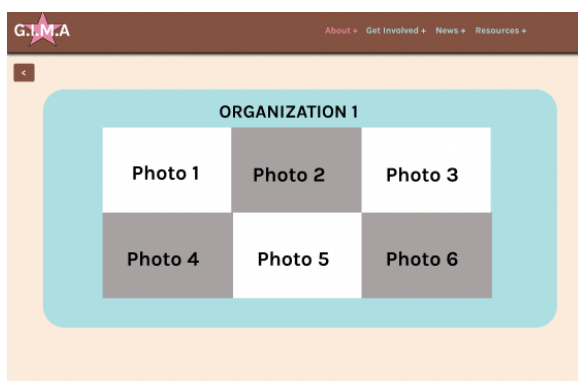
About Page: When you click *Team Structure*



About Page: Clicking Photos and Media



About page : When you click *Photos and Media*



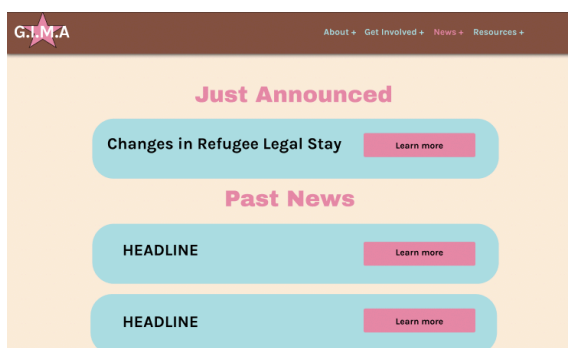
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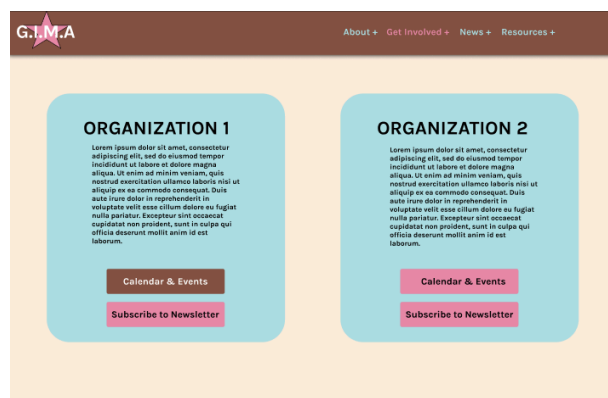
Resources Page: When you click on a tab



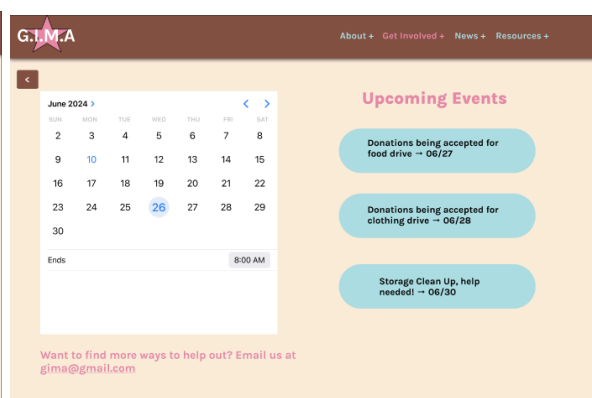
News Page:



Get Involved Page:



Get Involved Page: Calendar when clicked



By organizing the site into clear sections for Resources, News, and Initiatives, we aim to streamline communication, foster collaboration, and strengthen the broader local community. The website will also serve as an archive, and by increasing visibility for other organizations with similar missions, we hope to boost recruitment of student activists and volunteers.

The *Welcome* page will feature an interactive section where users can hover over organization logos and click to learn more. The *About* page will provide detailed descriptions of each organization, outline their team structure, and house a media archive. On the *Resources* page, users will find it easy to select the type of support they need and discover organizations that provide those resources. Recognizing the importance of keeping the community informed, we created a *News* page to share relevant local news and national updates. Lastly, the *Get Involved* page will offer quick access to organization descriptions, a link to a shared events calendar, and the option to subscribe to their newsletter, making it easier to engage new community members or student activists..

Conclusion

Throughout our research, we have learned how integral social media and digital spaces have been to furthering activist work in the face of censorship. Even when those in power attempt to take away digital space from activists to suppress their presence, advocates still find

ways to fight back and spread their message. However, fighting back does not always mean engaging in policy debates, which could lead to harsh repercussions on non-profit organizations. Sometimes it can involve carving a space on the web that is outside of larger institutional control to better serve their missions.

Based on the pain points mentioned by our community partners, we created an ideation website layout that would become that space. With the first low-fidelity iteration of our design ideation complete, we aim to expand our intervention further by creating a high-fidelity wireframe mockup that our community partners can engage with. Currently, we have received support from volunteers in O2 to participate in the review of our updated prototype, and we hope to also gain interest from O1 and O3. Additionally, one of the co-authors has been accepted as an activist fellow for O2 and will continue to update the prototype model throughout the summer. She will also be aiding in gathering legal resources and compiling them in a centralized document for future reference on the website. Another co-author will also help in the continuation of the project by helping with the live launch of the website if both the community partners and the institution's administration approve the model. Although the course is coming to a close, this is not going to be the end of the co-author's collective effort in creating a website that serves community partners who are carving a space of support during a time of fear and isolation.

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